

# The Paraphrase of Shem

**Codex Reference:** VII,1

**Translated by:** Michel Roberge and Frederik Wisse

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## Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Michel Roberge

Translated by Frederik Wisse

The first of the five tractates contained in Codex VII is entitled *The Paraphrase of Shem*. For its major part, this is an apocalypse, with the narrative frame describing the initial ascent of the seer, Shem (consistently spelled Seem), to the top of the creation (1,5-16) and his final return to the earth (41,21-42,11). The actual revelation is provided by Derdekeas, the son of the infinite Light; it consists of a cosmogony and an anthropology (1,16-24,29), followed by a history of salvation which focuses on the account of the Flood (24,29-28,8), the destruction of Sodom (28,8-30,4), the baptism of the Savior and his ascent on the occasion of his crucifixion (30,4-40,31). The revelation concludes with an address to Shem concerning his mission on earth (40,31-41,21). To this apocalypse are added a first eschatological discourse pronounced by Derdekeas (42,11-45,31), a description of Shem's ascent to the planetary spheres at the end of his life (45,31-47,32), a second eschatological discourse of Derdekeas (47,32-48,30) and, to conclude the whole tractate, a final address to Shem (48,30-49,9).

The cosmogonic myth reported here is related to those systems which consider the universe as rooted in three principles. It opens with the description of the three great powers or roots: at the top reigns Light Infinite, called "Majesty," which is Thought filled with hearing and word; located at the bottom is Darkness, a male principle which is "wind in the waters" and possesses the Mind (nous) wrapped with the restless fire. Between these two powers is the Spirit, a quiet and humble light. The harmony which prevails at the beginning derives from the fact that each of those roots reigns in itself without mixing with the other two. It is important to note that the text makes no allusion to any previous action taken by Darkness to seize the Mind, nor does it mention a fall of the Mind. However, the events are essentially triggered by the will of the Majesty in an effort to save the Mind.

Suddenly Darkness stirs and the Spirit discovers the existence of the bad root. By the will of the Great Light the waters separate and Darkness comes up with his eye, the Mind. The Spirit reveals himself to Darkness and by doing so loses a part of his light to the benefit of the Mind.

The exalted Light then reveals himself through his son, Derdekeas. He appears in the likeness of the Spirit, thus initiating the salvation of the Mind and the ascent of the Spirit's light. In order to deceive Darkness, the Savior provokes the creation of the universe from water, part of which transforms into a giant Womb (also called "Nature"). The restless fire goes to the Womb. Fooled by the fire, Darkness, on seeing the Womb, becomes unchaste, has intercourse with the Womb and ejaculates the Mind. Nature is then divided into four "clouds" or spheres, which are called Hymen, Chorion, Power and Water. On entering the Womb, the Mind collides with the

Unbegotten Spirit and the “burden of the Mind” causes “astonishment” in the Spirit. This power of Astonishment diverts the burden of Mind to the effect that, clothed with the light of the Spirit, he takes resort to the cloud of Power (also called “the Middle”). The Astonishment, however, sticks to the cloud of Hymen.

The Spirit beseeches the infinite Light to have mercy on his own light. The Savior appears this time as a whirlwind to blow up the clouds: they divide, and the Mind takes shape. Derdekeas puts on his universal garment of light and prompts the ascent of the light from the cloud of Water. When the Spirit gives thanks to the infinite Light, his Astonishment produces a great power, Thought, the principle of the race of Shem, the pneumatics.

Now the Savior deposits his universal garment and puts on his trimorphic garment in order to bring to perfection the light in the three clouds of Hymen, Silence (Chorion), and the Middle. The light retained in the Middle is the part of light which was detached from Astonishment and is united with Mind. After the Flood, it is called “Faith.”

The Savior descends to the cloud of the Middle, puts on a garment of fire and prostitutes himself with Nature. In its orgasm, the Womb casts off Mind in the form of a fish and gives birth to all sorts of beasts. Derdekeas puts on the garment of the Beast and prompts the Womb to produce heaven and earth and all kinds of seed. He also makes her give birth to female entities, the winds, and to male entities, the demons. The latter mate with the winds and thereby cast off the power they have, which is Mind. By the will of the Savior, Mind rules over the winds and the demons. He receives a likeness of fire, a light, a listening and a share of Logos. At the end of time, Mind will take his repose with Faith in the cloud of Hymen. The winds and the demons have intercourse for a second time and give birth to all sorts of impurity, that is, the material souls. Through the masturbation of one of the winds, barren women and sterile men are begotten. These are the psychics, who possess only a material soul and are bound to dissolve in Darkness. Finally the pneumatics come to existence, namely those who possess a particle of Mind and a thought from the light of Astonishment.

In order to detain the light of Faith and to destroy the pneumatic race, Nature plans to cause a flood, to which the Savior reacts by proclaiming the erection of a tower. Shem is saved and remains in a body so that he may have patience with Faith and pass on his revelation to postdiluvian mankind. In other words, during the time appointed to Faith, Shem and his race will live among the people who carry out the will of Nature through the observance of the law. For Nature uses the light of Faith under the form of the Law to keep to itself the noetic seed. After the flood, mankind in fact includes two classes of redeemed: the noetics, who possess a body, a soul, and a particle of Mind, and whose root is Faith, and pneumatics, who possess not only a particle of Mind but also a “thought” issued from Astonishment, and whose root is the Unbegotten Spirit.

The destruction of Sodom is also presented as an attempt by Nature to destroy the pneumatic seed. But Shem is told not to worry about his race, since thanks to his teaching they will bear the universal testimony and will repose in the place of the Unbegotten Spirit.

The Savior reveals himself for the last time when the demon (that is, John the Baptist) appears on the river in order to baptize. The baptismal rite is essentially bad because of its use of water—a primordial impure power, which in the beginning tried to detain the light of the Spirit and now

tries to keep men prisoner through baptism. But by descending on the water, the Savior rescues the light of Faith and reveals to the pneumatics and the noetics the passwords which will allow them to pass without hindrance through the planetary spheres as they return to their proper root. Thanks to the “memorial” (or “universal testimony”) the pneumatics ascend to the place of the Unbegotten Spirit; as for the noetics, they bear the “testimony of Faith” and ascend to Hymen, the place of Faith. This part of the tractate contains a harsh antibaptismal polemic, probably directed against the Great Church.

After his baptism, the Savior foretells his ascent at the end of his mission on earth. In its anger, Nature will try to seize him, but will only manage to crucify Soldas (that is, the terrestrial Jesus). The following allegory which narrates the beheading of Rebouel is intended to explain to the noetics the meaning of the crucifixion: it does not have the effect of purifying the water of baptism, but rather brings out the division between light and darkness. Just as Rebouel is declared blessed in her beheading, so the noetics should not hesitate to separate from the Great Church, which practises baptism, and enter the community of those who possess gnosis.

Former research has pointed out similarities between *The Paraphrase of Shem* and the tractate entitled *The Paraphrase of Seth*, which is referred to by the heresiologist Hippolytus in his report on the Sethians. But the differences between the two doctrines, especially with regard to anthropology, are too great to warrant the assumption of any direct or indirect link whatsoever between the two works. Likewise, more recent research tends not to regard *The Paraphrase of Seth* as a christianized version of *The Paraphrase of Shem*, which in that case could have been a witness of a pre-Christian Gnosticism.